WRITING
a film review

Discuss the topic

- Who is your favourite actor/actress/director?
- In your opinion, what makes a film successful?

Sample writing

1. Read the film review. Why did the writer like the film?

Recently, I saw the film *The Fellowship of the Ring* which is based on J.R.Tolkien's book. *The Fellowship of the Ring* is the first part of the trilogy *The Lord of the Rings*. This adventure film, full of fantasy, was directed by Peter Jackson and many great actors star in it.

The Fellowship of the Ring is about an ancient ring of power which finds its way into the hands of Bilbo Baggins after being lost for centuries. On his birthday, Bilbo gives the ring to his nephew Frodo. When Gandalf, the wizard, discovers that the ring belongs to the Dark Lord Sauron he tells Frodo that he must destroy it. There is only one way the ring can be destroyed. It must be thrown into the volcano Mt. Doom. So, Frodo and his friends set off on a dangerous journey to destroy the ring before Sauron gets his hands on it.

The film is action-packed and full of suspense. The special effects are amazing and the acting is excellent. There are lots of fantastic battle scenes and some really scary creatures. There are even some funny scenes with Gimli, the dwarf. However, the film is very long which makes it a bit tiring to sit through.

All in all, I liked the film a lot and I would definitely recommend it.

2. Find words in the review which mean:

a. play in a film _____
b. full of exciting events _____
c. excitement or anxiety you feel about what is going to happen _____
d. very good _____
e. suggest that something is suitable _____
f. frightening _____

3. Answer these questions by writing the numbers 1- 4 in the boxes.

In which paragraph does the writer:

a. describe the good and bad points of the film? ☐
b. describe the plot? ☐
c. introduce the film? ☐
d. give his/her general opinion about the film? ☐

Plan

Below is a general plan for a film review, with questions to guide you.

Introduction	• mention where and when you saw the film • give some general information about the film	*Did you see the film at the cinema or on TV?* *Did you watch it alone or with friends?* *What is the title of the film?* *What type of film is it?* *Who is the director?* *Who stars in this film?* *Who are the main characters? (could also be included in the main part)* *Where/When is the film set? (could also be included in the main part)*
Main part (2 paragraphs)	• state briefly the main events/points of the film (the plot) • make comments on the things you liked or didn't like about the film	*What is the film about?* *What are the main events?* *What happens to the characters?* *Is there anything you particularly liked or didn't like? (plot, acting, music, special effects, ending, etc.)*
Conclusion	• state your general opinion about the film • make a recommendation	*What do you think of the film?* *Would you recommend this film?*

Guide to writing

- Choose a film you know well and make a plan about what you are going to write.
- Mention only the main points of the plot. Do not include too many details.

- Use set phrases and expressions in your review. Look at the table for ideas.

Set phrases / expressions for the introduction		It's a comedy / an adventure film / a horror film, etc. ... stars in this film. ... is the leading actor/actress. ... plays/has the leading role. It was directed by ... The film is set in ...
Set phrases / expressions for the main part	PLOT	The film is about ... The hero/heroine of the film ...
	COMMENTS	The film is action-packed/full of suspense. It is interesting/moving/long/tiring. The acting is excellent/poor. The actors/actresses perform well/badly. The music is fantastic/awful. The special effects are amazing/unrealistic. Certain parts are funny/amusing. The ending is disappointing/(un)predictable/surprising.
Set phrases / expressions for the conclusion		All in all/Overall, I found the film exciting/boring. It's (only) suitable for children/adults. It's a great film for action-lovers. This film is a box-office hit and it's worth seeing. I definitely (do not) recommend it.

- Use the Present Simple when writing a film review. Note that when you are expressing your opinion about th film, you can also use the Past Simple.
- Use relative clauses introduced by relative pronouns (*who, which, etc.*) and adverbs (*where, when:* for time) i your film review.

Writing practice

1. **Complete the sentences a-h with phrases from the box below.**

- and has some beautiful scenery
- who is the leading actor in *Million Dollar Baby*
- because the ending was predictable
- and I particularly liked the performance of the leading actor
- which has many violent scenes
- that I bought the soundtrack the next day
- which are in Steven Spielberg's latest film
- who is played by an unknown actress

a. The special effects _____ are quite realistic.

b. This box-office hit is set in the French Alps _____

c. The heroine of the film, _____, tries to find her missing daughter.

d. I didn't like the film _____.

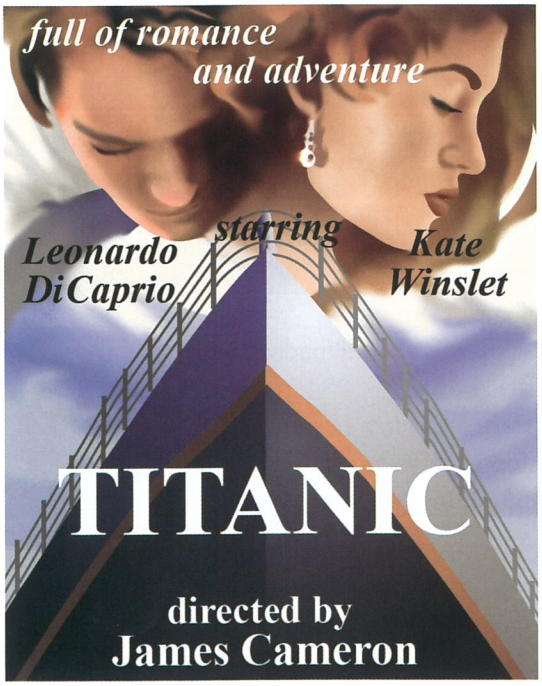
e. Clint Eastwood, _____, is also the director of that film.

f. I loved the music of the film so much _____.

g. It's an action-packed film _____ so it's not suitable for children.

h. The acting was excellent _____

2. **a. Below is a poster advertising the film *Titanic*. Using the information given, write an introduction for a f review of *Titanic*. Use the plan on page 53.**



_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

b. Complete the following paragraph about the plot of the film using the Present Simple of the verbs in the box.

begin | die | not manage | be | try | describe | not like | hit | remember | fall | survive | meet

The film _____ **1** a love story and _____ **2** the Titanic's tragic voyage and sinking. Rose, one of the main characters, is engaged to a rich man whom she _____ **3**. On the voyage, she _____ **4** a poor young artist, Jack, and _____ **5** in love with him. However, on the fourth night of the voyage, the Titanic _____ **6** an iceberg and _____ **7** to sink. Jack and Rose _____ **8** to save themselves. Sadly, Jack _____ **9** to survive and _____ **10**. However, Rose _____ **11** and _____ **12** Jack for the rest of her life.

c. Use the chart below to write the next paragraph (the comments) of the film review.

	Excellent	Good	Bad	Comments
Special effects	✓			spectacular
Acting		✓		really liked DiCaprio
Length of film			✓	too long / tiring
Ending		✓		unpredictable / sad

d. Read the two conclusions below. Which one do you think is more appropriate for the review above? Why?

A Overall, the film was disappointing. It was long and tiring. I definitely don't recommend it.

B Overall, I found the film very good. It's suitable for both children and adults and I think that it's worth seeing.

3. Your teacher has asked you to write a film review. Think of a film you have seen and make a plan in the sp below. You don't have to use all the points which are mentioned.

Introduction:

name of film: _____ at the cinema: ☐

type of film: _____ on TV: ☐

actors: _____ with friends: ☐

director: _____ alone: ☐

setting: place: _____

time: _____

Main part:

plot: _____

_____

_____

	excellent	good	bad	Comments
plot	☐	☐	☐	_____
special effects	☐	☐	☐	_____
acting	☐	☐	☐	_____
music	☐	☐	☐	_____
ending	☐	☐	☐	_____

Conclusion:

your opinion: _____

_____

recommend: Yes: ☐ No: ☐

4. Task for homework.
Write the film review using the plan you made in exercise 3.